Cecilia Hannon Calare NSW 2025 Federal Electorate Campaign

These are my observations as a Bathurst [redacted] Member on booth duties for prepoll on Saturday, 26 April 2025, at Bathurst Girl Guides Hall and on Election Day, 3 May 2025, at St Stephens' Presbyterian Church Hall, Howick Street, Bathurst (where I also scrutineered that evening).

Much of my submission deals with the impact on voters and party volunteers of *The Brethren* volunteers handing out for the [redacted] candidate. I was also unimpressed by behaviour of the [redacted] candidate himself, on the pre-poll day I volunteered, and disgusted by that of a particular [redacted] Party staffer on election day.

I also briefly discuss in this submission issues around HTV materials, corflutes in public spaces during the election campaign period and limited informal/formal votes knowledge displayed by at least one AEC staff at the booth where I scrutineered on election day.

1. Impact of The Brethren volunteers, their behaviour and the behaviour of other [redacted] representatives

Pre Poll Booth Duty – Saturday 26 April

I arrived late-morning at this booth to find more than twenty people, mostly young men, in bright yellow T-shirts which I later learnt this group were predominantly from *The Brethren* religious sect. They were an overwhelming presence far outnumbering volunteers for any other candidate.

As I entered the polling site, I saw that [redacted] candidate, [redacted], was learning up against the left-hand side of the gate entrance while Calare Independent MP, [redacted], was standing on the opposite side of the entrance. Candidate [redacted] appeared to be acting in a somewhat intimidating manner towards [redacted] in the way he was physically monopolising most of the gate entrance space, leaving the [redacted] in my opinion, with little personal space at his post.

This quick almost unconscious observation /summation of mine led me to warmly greet [redacted] as I walked into the booth to cast my vote fo[redacted], resplendent in my al[redacted] attire.

The entire time I was at the booth, firstly as a voter and then as a [redacted] volunteer, I observed there were between 15 and 20+ yellow t-shirted people making up [redacted] Brethren "swarm of bees" – as some of us later described them. They physically monopolised every voter who arrived at this booth by enthusiastically crowding around them flapping their [redacted] HTV's in front of the hapless person coming in the vote.

I have been volunteering for elections since the mid-1990s – firstly in Sydney's Inner West and more recently in the NSW Central West region. I can say with confidence I have never experienced such behaviour from other political party volunteers, including those fo[redacted]. This was my third election campaign in Bathurst. I did not recognise these people as Bathurst locals.

The sheer numbers of [redacted] volunteers, mostly Brethren people – seemed designed to make the [redacted] and other party volunteers as uncomfortable as possible. Meanwhile, it was no surprise to us when we observed one vocal Bathurst prestige property owning identity, casually swapping his [redacted] T-Shirt for a [redacted] T-Shirt!

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Election Day 3 May at Saint Stephen's Presbyterian Church Hall in Howick Street.

I arrived at this booth around 10am to find again, an overwhelming number of yellow T-shirted [redacted] supporters. They had a vast supply of campaign corflutes on A-frames blocking the footpath outside the church hall. Some people were only wanting to access the post office next to this church hall and were not even voting and were being physically impeded by the large [redacted] Party supporters.

The AEC booth captain came out at one stage; I spoke to her and complained that people were being prevented from going about their normal Saturday morning business in Howick Street and she replied that she would make "a note of it".

When I returned in the afternoon, things became even more hostile, as these [redacted] supporters had stepped up their discourteous behaviour towards the other candidates' volunteers. I was grateful for the company of the sole [redacted] supporter, the [redacted] supporter and workers for the other independent candidate, [redacted] as we all know each other from the 2023 Yes Campaign.

[redacted] volunteer [redacted] was particularly unpleasant. I later learned she is a current [redacted] Party staffer working for [redacted]. Her behaviour that afternoon was hostile and unprofessional in the way she interacted with other booth volunteers. If she was an [redacted] staffer, I would have been ashamed.

Whenever I came near our [redacted] A-frame – which [redacted] and other [redacted] volunteers were physically monopolising (to obscure [redacted] candidate [redacted] corflute profile) – she would loudly yell at me at me for no obvious reason, contriving some sort of grievance about my approach towards the [redacted] A Frame. This happened each time I tried to retrieve something from my backpack stored in the middle of the A- frame. I have never experienced this kind of behaviour on any previous election day, anywhere and whilst I can't recall her exact words I felt almost frightened, as well as puzzled and confused unable to process what was happening.

Another example of her behaviour was that she would come up and stand near me whilst I was talking to people and then loudly repeat the conversation all over Howick Street, in what seemed like a taunting, childish manner. I was shocked by this ill-mannered attack on my electioneering work.

Another [redacted] volunteer, a young man in a cowboy hat, was loudly instructing people to "*put a one down the bottom and two up the top*": that is, to vote 1 for [redacted] at the end of the ballot paper and then a 2 for the [redacted] candidate at the top of it. These were incorrect instructions: votes cast in exactly that way with no other numbering of the ballot paper created informal votes. As a result, there were 116 informal votes at the St Stephen's booth on election day.I am certain many can be linked to that [redacted] volunteer and his incorrect instructions to voters (plus the error of those ignorant enough to follow those instructions).

Civics Education, anyone??

I have outlined the intimidatory behaviours of [redacted] Party representatives at these two Bathurst booths because voters experiencing this last May might feel afraid when deciding to vote in future elections, notwithstanding Australia's compulsory voting system. Democracy and voting freedom is very precious and is being undermined when political party operatives intimidate. I would hope [redacted] officials might relay to the [redacted] Party administration and leadership, plus [redacted] the bad behaviour exercised by [redacted] party representatives in Bathurst.

Perhaps the [redacted] and [redacted] parties might rethink their volunteer recruitment choices and how they prepare their volunteers, staff and candidates for future campaigns.

Now to other matters.

2. HTV – How to Vote materials

I noted that a good number of voters appeared to be completely disinterested in taking the paper HTV's. I would assume that many people had already made up their minds while the younger generation voters were using their smart devices to get voting information. Perhaps we are seeing the beginning of the demise of the paper HTV's as a campaign tool at both at pre-poll and election day?

3. Corflutes in public spaces

I would like to see corflutes banned in public spaces - roads, fences, bridges, etc - and confined to personal property such as house fences. The volume of campaign collateral material around the Calare electorate for months before the May election date was announced, and during the campaign proper, predominately from the [redacted] and Independent, [redacted] was obscene.

That was an upside to [redacted] Bathurst campaign: having really no corflutes erected in public spaces in the Bathurst district given we had no available volunteers to do that task and limited corflutes due to lack of financial resources. Consequently, no work, post- election day, in having to take them down.

4. AEC volunteers

I was annoyed during my scrutineering duties at St Stephen's by the ignorance of one particular AEC worker. She was accepting clearly informal votes as formal and not really explaining why. I didn't bother challenging her after the first few informal votes, as I was confident that they would be counted as informal in the second check later in Orange. However, I do recall that whilst scrutineering on the night of the 2023 Voice Referendum, encountering the same situation with an AEC worker.